

1 INTRODUCTION

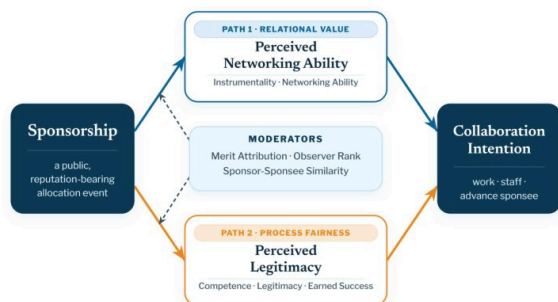
Sponsorship is third-party advocacy that places a candidate into a concrete opportunity, putting the sponsor's own reputation at risk, a mechanism long recognized as central to career advancement. It draws on social capital, the resources embedded in social networks that grant access to information, influence, and opportunity, and is typically framed in the literature as a career-enhancing function that positively shapes the sponsee's trajectories and outcomes.

Yet sponsorship is also a socially **ambiguous signal**: it conveys relational value, including network utility, political cover, and reach, while simultaneously raising questions about the sponsee's competence and the legitimacy of the relationship that produced the opportunity. Faced with this ambiguity, observers tend to lean more heavily on the signal itself, and on related heuristics, when forming judgments.

? RESEARCH QUESTION

How do sponsees and third-party observers diverge in interpreting a sponsorship event – and how does that divergence shape observers' willingness to collaborate with the sponsee?

2 THEORETICAL MODEL



- Observers weigh sponsorship's **relational value** (Path 1) against its **process fairness** (Path 2); moderators shift which pathway dominates.

Study 1 SELF-OTHER MISCALIBRATION

N = 150 · Prolific 3 perspectives Between-subjects



Figure 1. Evaluations across assessment perspective. Self > expected peer > peer for **competence, legitimacy, earned success** & willingness, while **instrumentality** reverses. One-way ANOVAs; all five effects significant.

- N = 150, Prolific; one identical sponsorship scenario
- Randomly assigned to one of three vantage points: **self** (sponsee's own assessment), **expected peer** (sponsee's metaperception), or **peer** (uninvolved observer's direct assessment)
- All groups rated the same five outcomes; one-way ANOVAs compared the three vantage points

★ **Takeaway:** From self to expected peer to peer, ratings drop on **competence, legitimacy, and earned success**, while **instrumentality** rises. Sponsees see their advancement as earned and fair; observers credit relational value (Path 1) but discount process fairness (Path 2) more than sponsees expect.

Study 2 PILOT · OBSERVER RANK

N = 86 students Peer vs. Superior Between-subjects

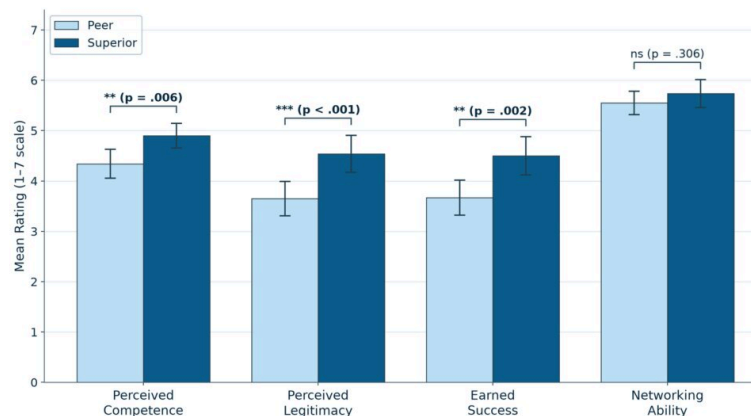


Figure 2. Superiors rate the sponsee higher on **competence, legitimacy & earned success**, but **networking ability** does not differ. Error bars = 95% CI.

- N = 86 business students; pilot testing observer rank
- Same scenario, randomly assigned to rate as a **peer** (fellow junior analyst) or a **superior** (sponsee's engagement manager)
- Independent-samples *t*-tests compared the two rank conditions

★ **Takeaway:** Superiors rated the sponsee significantly higher than peers on **competence, legitimacy, and earned success**, but **networking ability** showed no rank difference. Rank shifts the **fairness pathway** (Path 2) specifically, while **relational value** (Path 1) stays untouched.

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SELECTED REFERENCES

Campbell & Shea (2025) · Casciaro & Lobo (2008) · Conlon et al. (2004) · Connelly et al. (2011) · Ferris et al. (2005) · Hewlett (2013) · Ibarra et al. (2010) · Kelley (1973) · Lind (2001) · Pronin et al. (2004) · Spence (1973) · Tyler (2006). Full reference list & study materials available on request.